

Volunteer follow-up — a few questions before we build

Thank you for making time for this. Below is what we're building and the handful of things only JA can tell us. **Happy to talk it through, or you're welcome to reply in writing by number if that's easier** — either works.

What we're building

JA surveys volunteers after every program. Buried in the free-text answers are people saying they'd like to do more — come back next year, join a committee, introduce their employer, refer a colleague, speak, or give. Reading every response to find them isn't anyone's actual job, so those offers tend to go uncalled.

We're building a tool that reads the free text and produces a list of those people, **sorted by which JA team should follow up**, with the sentence that triggered each one shown alongside it. It doesn't send email and doesn't touch your CRM — it produces a list your staff can act on.

The part we can't do without you is judgment. We can detect that someone expressed interest; we can't know what that interest is worth to JA, or who should receive it.

Questions

1. How does JA weigh these different kinds of interest?

This is the one we'd most like your thinking on, and the one we can't work out for ourselves.

The survey responses point to six kinds of interest: **volunteering again, committee or board service, corporate sponsorship, referring a colleague, speaking, and giving**. We can find all six. What we don't know is how JA would prioritize them.

- If twenty of these landed on your desk and you had time to call five today, which would you call first — and what makes them first?
- For each of the six, what does a good outcome actually look like? A repeat classroom volunteer and a sponsor conversation seem like different orders of magnitude on different timelines, but we'd rather hear it from you.
- Is a tentative sponsorship signal worth more than an enthusiastic repeat volunteer? That trade-off comes up on nearly every response.
- Does who the person is change the weight? We have their employer and their role. Does a senior person at a large employer offering an introduction count differently from the same sentence written by someone else?
- In your experience, what separates a genuine signal from ordinary politeness? You've read far more of these than we have.

If the honest answer is "it depends," that's genuinely useful — we can build in conditions. We'd rather capture how JA actually thinks about this than impose a scoring system of our own.

2. Which teams receive these leads, and what does each one handle?

We know from Rachael that staff currently email leads on to other teams. We know three of those handoffs — development for a committee prospect, corporate partnerships for an employer introduction, program staff for a repeat classroom volunteer.

For the other three — referrals, speaking, and giving — **we've guessed**, and one of our guesses assumes a volunteer-recruitment function that may not exist at JA. We'd rather be corrected than ship our assumptions.

What are the actual teams, and what is each responsible for?

3. Who specifically receives them?

The team tells us how to sort; the person tells us where it goes. Does any one person cover more than one of these areas? If so we'll group their leads into a single handoff rather than several.

4. Is there volunteer or survey data from previous years?

Right now we only see a single point in time. With any history, we could weight a lead by how recently someone volunteered, how often they've come back, and — for giving — what they've given before. Someone in their fourth year saying "count me in again" is a stronger lead than a first-timer writing the same words.

- Do prior-year survey exports exist?
- Is it tracked when someone volunteers across multiple years or programs?
- Is there giving history that could be matched to a volunteer?

Please don't pull anything on our account — we're only asking whether it exists. If it's something already sitting in a file, great; if it would mean an export from your CRM, it isn't worth your weekend and we'll build without it.

5. How does the handoff work today?

Is it an email per lead, a weekly batch, a shared spreadsheet, something else? We've assumed individual leads going to individual people, and if that's wrong we'd like to know before we build the wrong thing.

6. Who handles a volunteer who had a bad experience?

Roughly 7% of responses contain a specific, fixable complaint. We'd like to surface those as a separate list rather than lose them. Is that the same person who receives the re-engagement leads, or someone else?

If you have more time

Not essential — useful if you're inclined.

- Roughly how many of these come through per program cycle?

- What does the receiving person need in order to act — name and email, or more context?
 - Does anyone find out afterward whether a lead actually converted?
 - Rachael mentioned JA isn't tied to the current survey questions. If you could add one or two structured questions to the survey itself, what would you want to ask?
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We'll share what we build with JA regardless of how far we get in the day, along with a short note on where it's reliable and where it isn't.

— Chris Lacey